



# Communicating Trade-Offs

Week 6 • Day 3 • Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation

TPM Academy



## Day 3 Objectives

- Translate a technical trade-off into the **stakeholder's currency**
- Apply the "**need to know vs need to decide**" frame
- Write a **1-page brief** that fits on one page (the constraint is forcing)
- Predict the stakeholder's **top 5 questions**
- Cross-review in role + AI-critique to surface gaps



# Today's Shape

| Clock         | Block                       | Outcome                                            |
|---------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:15 | Opening                     | Pin SEP §§1–2 + TCD §5 trade-offs on the wall      |
| 09:15 – 10:30 | Block 1 + Activity 1        | Translation drill (6 examples)                     |
| 10:45 – 12:00 | Block 2 + Activity 2        | Pick trade-off + stakeholder + predict 5 questions |
| 13:00 – 14:15 | Block 3 + Activity 3        | Draft the 1-page brief                             |
| 14:30 – 16:00 | Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap | Cross-review (in role) + AI critique               |

# Block 1 — The Translation Discipline

Same trade-off, expressed in their currency



# Translation Is Re-Framing

| Technical framing                             | Business framing                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Async write to audit; sync would breach p95" | "Ship 50ms faster; audit logs lag 10s. Important for Q3 compliance review timing."                       |
| "Denormalized ticket_ids array"               | "Optimizing reconcile reads at the cost of a future query type. We'd revisit if that query becomes hot." |
| "Modular monolith, not a service"             | "Shipping faster by not separating this code; we accept the cost of a future split if traffic grows 5x." |

**Currency by stakeholder:** CFO → cost. Customer Success → customer outcome. Compliance → regulatory exposure. Eng Director → velocity.

# "Need to Know" vs "Need to Decide"

## Need to know

- Headline outcome
- Cost we're accepting
- Trigger to revisit
- What we need from them

## Need to decide

- Approve the choice?
- Cost acceptable?
- Trigger well-chosen?
- Provide what we need?

**Strip everything else.** Detail goes in the appendix or "available on request."

# Activity 1 — Translation Drill

Triads • 35 minutes

6 technical statements, each paired with a stakeholder. Pick 3; translate each.

- 5 min: pick 3 of the 6
- 20 min: translate using audience currency
- 10 min: critique the translations (would the stakeholder act?)



5 + 20 + 10

# Block 2 — Pick + Predict

Trade-off + stakeholder + their first 5 questions





# Picking the Pairing

| Pick criteria         | What this means             |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------|
| Decision-shaped       | There's a real call to make |
| Stakeholder has power | They can approve or block   |
| Non-obvious cost      | Needs explaining            |

**5 predicted questions:** at least one should be hostile. If all 5 are friendly, you're not stress-testing.

## Activity 2 — Pick + Predict

Triads • 40 minutes

- 5 min: review TCD §5 + TMD trade-offs
- 10 min: pick the trade-off
- 10 min: pick the stakeholder
- 15 min: predict 5 questions, ranked, with at least 1 hostile



5 + 10 + 10 + 15

# Block 3 — Draft the 1-Page Brief

The 1-page constraint is forcing



# The 1-Page Template

```
# Trade-off brief: <feature>
**For:** <stakeholder> | **From:** <triad> | **Date:** ...

<h2 id="the-decision-1-sentence">The decision (1 sentence)</h2>
<p>We are choosing [X] over [Y], accepting [cost].</p>
<h2 id="why-this-matters-to-you-12-sentences-in-their-currency">Why this matters to you (1-2 sentences in their currency)</h2>
<p>...</p>
<h2 id="the-choice">The choice</h2>
<ul>
<li>What we're doing: ...</li>
<li>What we're explicitly NOT doing: ...</li>
<li>The cost we're accepting: ...</li>
</ul>
<h2 id="what-would-change-our-mind">What would change our mind</h2>
<concrete trigger="">

<h2 id="what-we-need-from-you">What we need from you</h2>
<p><input type="checkbox"/> Approval to proceed
<input type="checkbox"/> Specific concern to address
<input type="checkbox"/> Information we don't have</p>
<h2 id="appendix-linked">Appendix (linked)</h2>
</concrete></triad></stakeholder></feature>
```

• TCD \$5 / TMD \$X / SLO budget



# Worked Brief (Async Audit Write for Compliance)

```
## The decision
Async audit write (1-10s lag) over synchronous to keep
dispatcher reconcile screens fast.

<h2 id="why-this-matters-to-you">Why this matters to you</h2>
<p>Affects audit-trail timing your SOC 2 process depends on.
Audit events are still durable (Kafka topic + DLQ) – they
just appear in audit store 1-10 seconds after the action.</p>
<h2 id="the-choice">The choice</h2>
<ul>
<li>Doing: Publish to Kafka topic at user-action; consumer
writes to audit store within 1-10s.</li>
<li>NOT doing: Sync write on user's hot path (would add
30-80ms; breaks p95 SLO).</li>
<li>Cost: A regulator querying within 5s of an event sees
stale state.</li>
</ul>
<h2 id="what-would-change-our-mind">What would change our mind</h2>
<p>A regulator or customer contractually requires sync audit
visibility within < 1 second.</p>
<h2 id="what-we-need-from-you">What we need from you</h2>
```

- ☐ Approval that 1-10s lag is acceptable for SOC 2
- ☐ Confirmation of acceptable lag bound (we propose  $\leq 10s$  p99)
- ☐ Note of any contract requiring sync audit (we know of none)

# Activity 3 — Draft the Brief

Triads • 40 minutes

- 5 min: decision sentence
- 10 min: why this matters (cross-check vs predicted Q1)
- 10 min: doing / not doing / cost
- 5 min: change-our-mind trigger
- 5 min: what we need (specific checkboxes)
- 5 min: appendix linkbox



5 + 10 + 10 + 5 + 5 + 5

# Block 4 — Cross-Review (in Role) + AI

Read the brief as the stakeholder would

# In-Role Reading

Reviewer triad reads the brief **as if they were the stakeholder**. They underline:

- Sentences that **lose them** (jargon, irrelevant, unclear)
- Sentences they'd **push back on**
- The **first question** they'd ask

**Author triad listens; does not defend.** Same Week-3 review discipline.





# AI in Role

```
Role: <stakeholder type="" =="" cfo,="" compliance="" lead,="" sales="" vp="">
```

```
Context: <paste the="" brief="">
```

```
Task: Read this as the named stakeholder.
```

- First question you'd ask?
- Concern that's unaddressed?
- Word or phrase that loses you?

```
Constraints:
```

- Specific to the brief, not generic
- Voice the stakeholder honestly

```
Format: Numbered – Question / Concern / Word.</paste></stakeholder>
```

## Activity 4 — In-Role Review + AI

Triad pairs • 45 minutes • Wrap

- 10 min: reviewer triad reads in role; underlines
- 10 min: author triad listens to feedback
- 15 min: AI critique in role
- 10 min: adopt / defer / reject + update §3



10 + 10 + 15 + 10 • 15-min wrap

# Day 3 Wrap

## What we built

- Translation discipline (currency by stakeholder)
- "Need to know vs need to decide" frame
- 1-page brief for one trade-off + stakeholder
- Cross-reviewed in role + AI-critiqued
- SEP §3 drafted

## What opens tomorrow

- **AI-augmented requirement summaries**
- Meeting prep: prior context, predicted objections, opening
- Validation discipline (Wk 5 D5)

**Bring to Day 4:** SEP §§1–3. Tomorrow we prep for the Friday simulation using AI.

# Questions & Reflection

Which trade-off in your TCD would you most want to brief tomorrow?